



the by-elections, coming less than a year ahead of the general elections, are an acid test for Reddy too.

Even as several political heavyweights have declined to contest against TRS on Congress tickets, fearing that they would be perceived as being anti-Telangana, Andhra Pradesh Congress Committee President D. Srinivas argues that the by-elections cannot be seen as a referendum. "Our party leaders were the first to ask for a separate Telangana. The question of a referendum would crop up only if we said no to the idea, and we never did," says Srinivas. But Congress as well as TDP cadres in the region are likely to vote for TRS candidates in large numbers, in support of the Telangana sentiment. BJP, too, is in favour of a separate state.

TDP chief N. Chandrababu Naidu has meanwhile taken advantage of the by-elections to join hands with CPI(M) to make it a tough triangular contest in most constituencies. The irony is that though TDP was anti-Telangana, it had done well in these constituencies before the advent of TRS. No sooner was

the poll schedule announced than a carefully ambiguous Naidu declared, for the first time, that his party is not against the formation of Telangana and that the issue will be discussed by a five-man committee of the party before taking a final stand. "There are conflicting demands, with sections in Telangana and coastal Andhra Pradesh pitching for separate states and others opposing the idea. The best way is to discuss the issue thoroughly and then arrive at a decision," says Naidu. Rao believes that Naidu is not serious about the division of Andhra Pradesh. "If he is sincere, let his party write to the Cabinet Subcommittee headed by Minister for External Affairs Pranab Mukherjee, withdrawing its letter supporting a unified state of Andhra Pradesh," he says. Clearly, Naidu, whose communist allies are against a division, is keeping his options open in a bid to regain lost ground in the region.

All this makes it a now-or-never situation for TRS if it is to carry its separatist campaign forward. An acerbic Rao accuses the Congress and

SELECTIVE RETENTION: TRS legislators are riding a wave of unpopularity

TDP of conspiring to defeat his party nominees in four Assembly constituencies and says that they have joined hands only to claim later, once the results are announced, that there is no Telangana sentiment in the region. "There is no difference between the two parties. Both the Congress and TDP regimes killed Naxalites in encounters, failed to stop farmer suicides, sold Wakf properties and diverted funds meant for Scheduled Castes and Tribes. Their flags may be different but their agenda is the same," says Rao. Unfazed, Reddy believes voters will not be carried away by the Telangana factor alone. "There is a strong sentiment for a new state, but the overriding factor will be development. Since Independence, no government in the country has done as much on the development front as ours," he claims.

As the parties gear up for the battle, the grim prospect of violence is surfacing. Maoists, known to step up militancy at election time, might make polling a taxing affair for the state administration. And with Telugu superstar Chiranjeevi threatening to jump into the fray in time for the general elections, things can only get more theatrical.

"Sections in Telangana and coastal Andhra want statehood, but others are opposed to it."

N. CHANDRABABU NAIDU, TDP PRESIDENT

